12

QUARANTINE

On Saturday, October 20, it looked as if some unknown virus had hit the entire leadership of the United States. President Kennedy interrupted his three-day, five-state campaign trip in the Midwest, where he was speaking in support of Democratic candidates to Congress, because of a cold. He was returning to the capital. Vice President Lyndon Johnson cut short his stay in Honolulu and headed back to Washington, also citing a cold.

The White House press secretary, Pierre Salinger, broke the news to reporters about Kennedy's change of plans as they boarded a bus at the Sheraton-Blackstone Hotel in Chicago to follow the president to his next campaign stop in Milwaukee. He told the reporters that the president had developed a "slight upper respiratory infection" and was taking "normal medication for a cold, aspirins and antihistamines." His body temperature was allegedly one degree above normal. The reporters were incredulous: Kennedy looked normal. Pierre Salinger was equally suspicious and decided not to return on the press plane but to join the president on Air